

Finding the AI use cases worth your time.

Responsible AI Hackathon | How to identify and evaluate high-value AI use cases in your department



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The picture today

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The ambition is real

Government wants to do a lot with AI.

In January 2025 the government accepted all 50 recommendations of the AI Opportunities Action Plan and put a £45bn a year productivity prize on the table. The Humphrey toolset is already in Whitehall: the Consult tool alone is projected to save around 75,000 days of analysis a year.

THE DIRECTION FROM THE TOP

“Mainline AI into the veins of the nation.” The appetite has never been higher.

All 50

recommendations of the AI Opportunities Action Plan, accepted by government. (Jan 2025)

£45bn

a year: the productivity prize identified from digital and AI in the public sector. (2025)

But the needle isn't moving

Ambition is running ahead of production.

30%

of UK public-sector staff have integrated AI into how they work. Another 65% are still only experimenting. (FSP / Microsoft, 2025)

THE GOVERNMENT'S OWN VERDICT

One year on, departments are only “beginning to properly scale” AI, with flagship tools going national in 2026–27. (DSIT, Jan 2026)

IT'S NOT A GOVERNANCE PROBLEM

The blocker is execution

Skills

70% of government bodies struggle to recruit and keep AI-skilled staff.

Foundations

62% are held back by data quality, and 28% of central systems are legacy IT.

Focus

MIT finds 95% of GenAI pilots still return nothing. The winners start from the right use case.

Finding the right use case

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Not all AI is equal

Match the level of ambition to the problem.

Copilots and assistants

Help staff draft, summarise and answer faster. Sit on top of tools people already use.

EXAMPLE

A caseworker copilot that summarises notes and drafts a plain-English response.

Insight and decision support

Predict risk, demand or outcomes to drive better decisions. Humans still make the call.

EXAMPLE

Models that flag high-risk maintenance, vulnerable households or demand spikes.

AI in the workflow

Embedded in core processes. Automates routine steps: reading, checking, routing, scheduling.

EXAMPLE

Document understanding for applications: extract, validate, route to the right team.

Agents and service redesign

Multi-step agents that act across systems. Power new services, not just faster old ones.

EXAMPLE

An incident-response agent that gathers evidence, drafts comms and opens tasks.

Start with outcomes

What separates the 5% that work.

01

Solves a root-cause problem

Re-engineer the whole process, not a single step in a workflow. Fix the cause, not the symptom.

02

Delivers long-term ROI

Align to a strategic aim so it scales. Reuse modular, repeatable assets across the next use case.

03

Builds trust in AI

Deliver measurable value, keep it explainable, and bring users with you.

WHERE THIS ROOM HAS THE EDGE

Baselines, measurement and honest evaluation are what separate a demo from real value. They're also the heart of responsible AI, and exactly the instincts you already have.

Which ones are worth it?

Four questions before anything reaches the build list.

Cross-team impact

Does it touch more than one team?

Leadership support

Does someone senior enough care?

Measurable

Can we quantify the result?

Strong foundations

Can we do this without fixing our data first?

AND ONE MORE, THE THEME OF TODAY

Can we do it responsibly? Explainable, and monitored for fairness. If the answer to any of these is no, park it.

Starting fast

Our use case identification & solution design accelerator

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Use case identification & solution design

How we identify and contextualise high-value use cases

Goals:

- Identify the highest ROI use case opportunity areas
- Down-select one high-priority use case
- Bring AI solution design to the line of business
- Produce a business case

Features:

- Duration: 2 weeks
- Activities: Meetings, workshops, prototype solution design
- Client participants: Business area leads & SMEs
- Manuka team: AI Architect & Business Consultant

Outputs:

- Value chain map for client's business
- Several value 'hotspots' identified
- One high-value use case high-level design
- Business case for priority use case
- Easy next steps defined to move the product to prototype and MVP build

Stage 1: Value chain mapping

Stage 2: Use case identification & prioritisation, business case



Workshops, interviews, research and write-up. 2-week timeline.



Current state
assessment playback

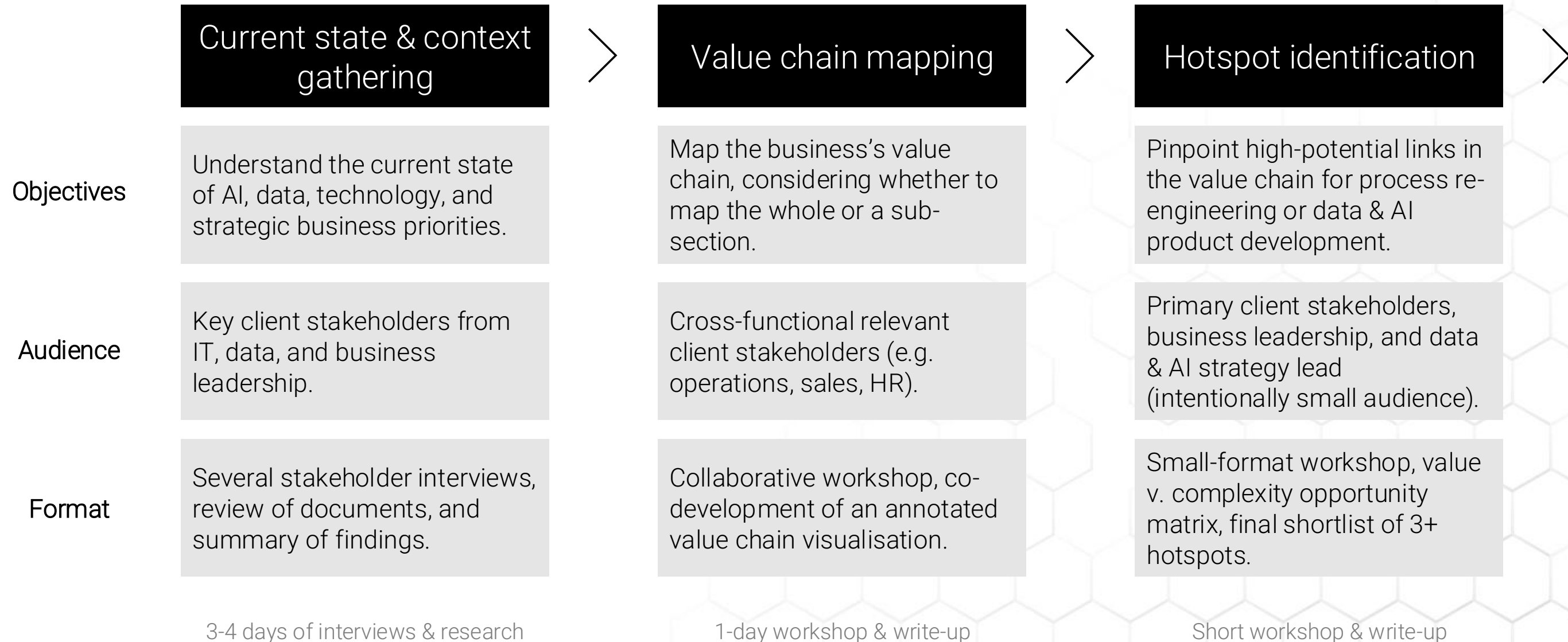
Pipeline of high-priority
use cases playback

Business case
playback



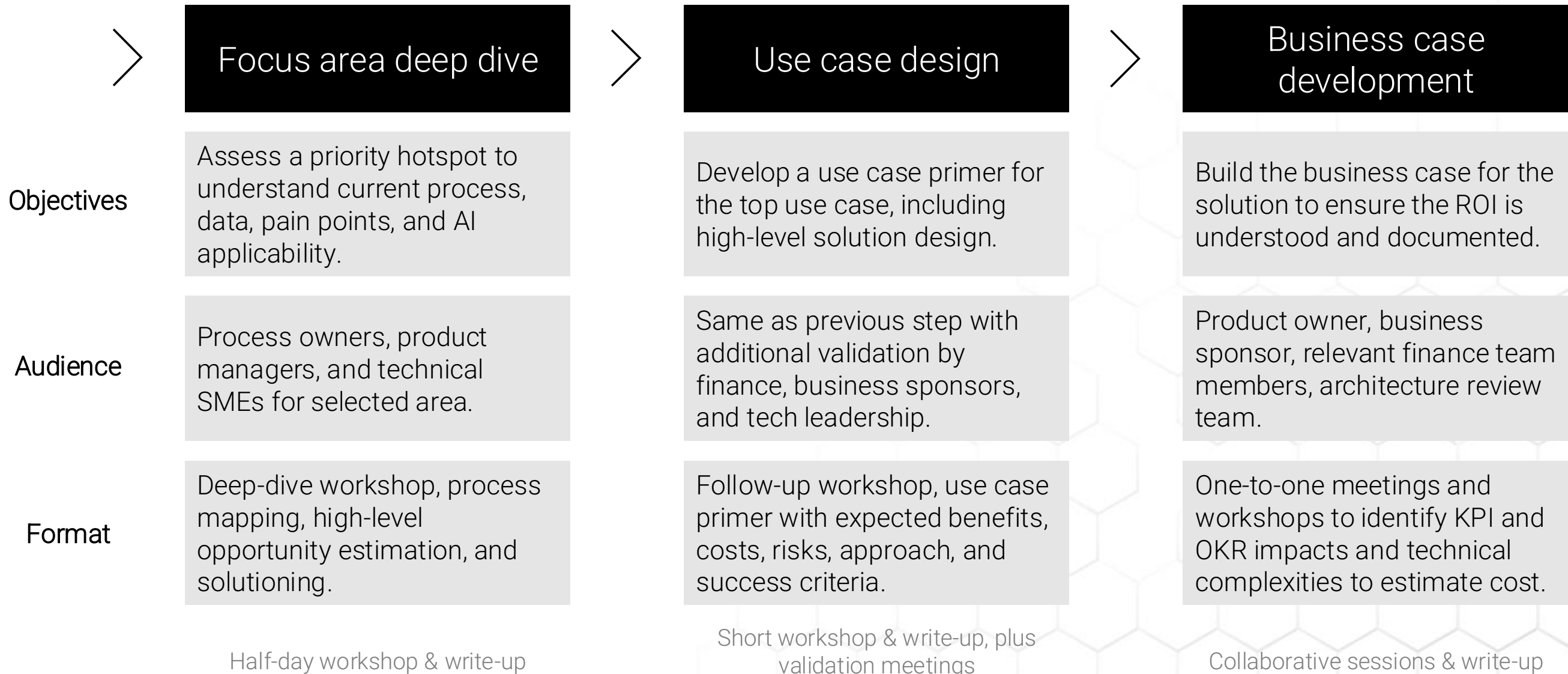
Use case accelerator

Stage 1 – Value chain mapping



Use case accelerator

Stage 2 – Use case identification & prioritisation, business case development



Tools & techniques

The methodologies and accelerators we use, developed over many projects

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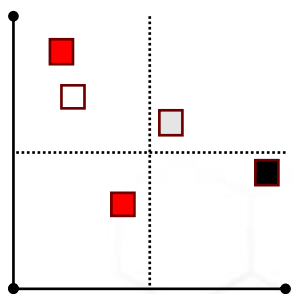
Our hotspot identification workshop

Hotspot identification

- Identify 'hotspots' in the organisation's value chain. This can be based on:
 - Areas that add the most value** as part of the existing chain (the most important parts and key differentiators of your business).
 - Areas with the most potential for growth** in value (areas you haven't yet fully capitalised on).
 - Areas with the most issues** in complexity or quality (for example, a frequent customer complaint may be interaction with customer services).
 - 'Low hanging fruit' areas** with a fast, easy, and obvious road to value for an AI use case.

Value versus complexity matrix

- Write a 'back of the napkin' summary of the problem, solution, and potential value for each hotspot.
- Plot each hotspot relatively on a matrix with 'value' on the y axis and 'complexity' on the x axis.



Shortlisting & next steps

- Take a subset of the hotspots in the top-left quadrant (high value, low complexity) and progress these to the deep-dive stage.

Value case primer template			
1 THE PROBLEM	2 THE SOLUTION	3 THE USER	4 THE DELIVERY PLAN
Business problem statement - What is the business problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Proposed solution - What is the proposed solution? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Who's affected? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Technology dependencies & delivery plan - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?
Value of solution (best case - do nothing) - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Metrics - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Surface sketch - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Business process change - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?
Data sources required - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Stakeholder engagement - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Stakeholder engagement - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?	Stakeholder engagement - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business? - What is the impact of the problem? - What is the current state of the business?



We will tailor the agenda and format of each stage to optimise it for you and your stakeholders.

Value case primer example

1 THE PROBLEM

Business problem statement

- Describe the business pain point.
- The problem should be significant; something shareholders care about.
- How are things like time, cost, & quality affected?

Value at stake (best case v. do nothing)

- How will we benefit if we have a perfect solution?
- Quantify the potential business impact and value.
- How is P&L affected? E.g. revenues, costs, efficiencies, time, quality, & market differentiation.

2 THE SOLUTION

Proposed analytical solution

- What's the analytical solution to this business problem?
- Are we explaining, predicting, quantifying, prioritising, classifying, optimising? Trying to maximise one thing by minimising another?

Metrics

- What metrics will we use to measure success?
- Are these already in place or is work needed to implement further instrumentation?

Data sources required

- What internal data sources would be required?
- Are they likely to be of suitable quality & reliability?
- What third-party/external data sources could be used?
- Will personal data need to be processed?

3 THE USER

Who's affected?

- Who are the actors in the process?
- What are the decisions they make?
- How often do they need to make these decisions & take actions?
- What tools do they already use?
- What context are they in; physical & mental?

Surface sketch

- How is the product going to be consumed?
- Will it be consumed programmatically, e.g. via an API?
- Does the output need to be explainable? I.e. how much does the user need to know why the model is saying what it is?
- Does it need to be interactive? I.e. does the user need to modify inputs to iterate different results?
- What devices is most suitable?
- What format is suitable; visual/audio/chat/CSV/email?
- Sketch what it might look like.

4 THE DELIVERY PLAN

Technology dependencies & considerations

- What enterprise architecture preferences should be considered?
- What technology capability already exists within the business?

Business process change

- How significant are the business changes required to support the adoption of the solution?
- How many users do we anticipate & what is a sensible roll-out plan?

Risks & milestones

- What other strategic initiatives are underway that might affect this? E.g. capacity constraints.
- What technical risks should we prepare to mitigate? E.g. PII data, infosec, unproven tech, etc.
- What resistance might there be in the business to adoption?

Applying this to the public sector

Value levers and beyond

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Public sector value levers

What 'value' really means in government.

Citizen and service-user outcomes

Reach the eligible sooner. Fewer people fall through the cracks.

MEASURE % eligible reached, time to service

Staff capacity released

Cut the manual chasing, drafting and checking. Give people their time back.

MEASURE Hours saved per case, cases per FTE

Cost avoidance and efficiency

Do more within a flat budget. Strip out rework and duplicate spend.

MEASURE Spend per outcome, rework reduced

Risk, fraud and safeguarding

Catch error, fraud and vulnerability earlier. Lower legal and reputational exposure.

MEASURE Error / fraud rate, cases caught earlier

Speed and backlog reduction

Clear waiting lists and casework faster. Shorten the decision cycle.

MEASURE Waiting-list days, decision cycle time

Trust, evidence and defensibility

Better evidence, auditable decisions, fair and explainable models.

MEASURE Audit coverage, bias / fairness metrics

The multiplier is reuse: one data foundation that feeds the next use case, and the next.

What good looks like

Where we'd look first, by department.

Department	The hotspot	A catalyst use case (and the lever)
DfE / Office for Students	Attendance, attainment and wellbeing sit in different systems. Lots of manual chasing.	A daily pupil / student engagement lens that flags drift early, then fast-tracks support (free school meals, catch-up, SEND assurance). Lever: citizen outcomes + risk
DESNZ	Household, energy and eligibility data sit apart. Support reaches people late.	Fuel-poverty and energy-support targeting from one list of households, plus an asset and outage hotspot lens for the network. Lever: citizen outcomes + speed
DSIT	Policy, research and guidance scattered across directorates. PQs and grant oversight eat analyst time.	A cross-government knowledge assistant and a PQ-drafting agent on Hansard; grant-portfolio intelligence across UKRI and Innovate UK. Lever: staff capacity + defensibility
Home Office / Met Police / ONS	Casework triage is manual. Statistical production and data linkage are labour-heavy.	Document understanding and case triage; entity resolution and survey classification for ONS, built on trustable baselines. Lever: speed + evidence quality

Working it live

One board, four frames, 45 minutes. How the session runs.

01

5 min

Introductions and context

Who's in the room, both teams.
Agree what we want from today, and why.

02

10 min

Business strategy and priorities

Capture the strategy. Post the top three or four priorities, and the value levers under each.

03

25 min

Strategic priority deep dive

Pick the priority that matters most.
Work it four ways: details, goals, use cases, ideate.

04

5 min

Next steps

Agree what's ready to design and build, and where more strategy or ideation is needed.

The value levers feed Part 2. The four-question filter and the value-vs-complexity grid feed Part 3. Public data only for anything we build.

Find the problem worth solving. Then build.

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Manuka AI x Databricks x RSS AI Task Force

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